ASSEMBLY POLLS 2023

KARNATAKA

THE LINGAYAT FACTOR

WITH AN ESTIMATED 17 PER CENT OF KARNATAKA'S POPULATION, THE COMMUNITY HAS BEEN CRUCIAL IN EVERY ELECTION IN THE STATE, MORE SO FOR THE RULING BJP, WHICH THE LINGAYATS HAVE FIRMLY BACKED FOR NEARLY TWO DECADES NOW

By Ajay Sukumaran



THREE DAYS BEFORE he turned 80 on February 27, B.S. Yediyurappa bid adieu to the Karnataka legislative assembly, thereby drawing the curtains on a 40-year career as a legislator. It was an emotional moment for the man who was once the BJP's lone MLA in the state and who, 15 years ago, led the party to its first government in Karnataka. He was again at the helm in 2019 when the BJP seized power for a second term. Over the past year, the former chief minister has signalled that he won't be fighting another assembly election, but he was clear that he wasn't hanging up his boots yet—there was, as Yediyurappa pointed out in his farewell address, unfinished business at hand.

The task that Yediyurappa has set for himself is to bring the BJP back to power in May—no minor feat given that the last time a ruling party returned to power in Karnataka was in 1985. For the BJP, there's the added challenge: despite Karnataka being its 'gateway to the south,' the party has not yet won an outright majority in a state election.

But, at 80, it would seem that Yediyurappa is defying some familiar BJP formulae—notably, the retirement criterion for veterans. For someone who stepped down from the CM's post midway through his term, in July 2021, and is firm about not contesting the upcoming election, Yediyurappa is still the mainstay in campaigns even while the party is banking heavily on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's charisma. At recent election rallies, his was the name that the top brass invoked, more than that of Chief Minister Basavaraj Bommai who succeeded him. On Yediyurappa's birthday on February 27, Modi visited his home district of Shivamogga to inaugurate a new airport, the rich accolades to him leaving no ambiguity about how highly the party values him. In fact, in Belagavi on the same day, the PM contrasted this with how the Congress, in its heyday, had treated popular leaders—notably S. Nijalingappa and Veerendra Patil, both former CMs. In that fell swoop, as political observers see it, the PM made a play for the one vote that is crucial in Karnataka—the Veerashaiva-Lingayats, who make up the largest electoral bloc at an estimated 17 per cent of the state's population. Like Yediyurappa, both Nijalingappa and Patil were from the same community.

Tracing their faith to the 12th century philosopher and social reformer Basavanna, the Veerashaiva-Lingayats are a large community made up of about 87 sub-castes. Prominent among these are the Sadar Lingayat, to which CM Basavaraj Bommai belongs; Banajiga Lingayat from which his predecessor B.S. Yediyurappa hails; and Panchamashali, believed to be the most numerous. Karnataka has had nine Lingayat CMs so far.

The Lingayat vote has been a significant factor in every election result in Karnataka, more so for the BJP, which the community has firmly backed for nearly two decades now. Back in 1989, Yediyurappa was the BJP's only Lingayat MLA; by 2004, it had as many as 34. In the following state election